

In-App-ropriate

I assume you'll be reading this sometime after May 1, 2015. Apart from being Labour Day in India (and some other countries), it's a day that we've been told will be a first of its sort in technology. Fashion site, Myntra (owned by Flipkart) is supposed to pull down the shutters on its website and become an app-only entity. It's a bold move. And to be honest, I think we need such boldness in India. Too many companies are just too scared to take risks these days, and that stifles innovation and bores consumers.

That doesn't mean I think it will work.

Apple has been well known for locking you into its ecosystem and its products... So you want to watch a video on your phone? Not unless you transfer it from a system running iTunes! You want a different keyboard? *sniggers* (And yet, now Apple offers it.)

Before Apple, it was Microsoft. Go on, go ahead and pirate more, you miserable scallywag, but when you get to work, your company will have to pay me because you'll never know any other OS, and I'll laugh all the way to the bank. And I'll charge insane prices for my Office Suite too, just because I can! (Now, however, Office is cheap and Windows 10 is free.)

Here's the thing about monopolies. Like dictatorships, they eventually end – in flames, with screaming and gore, and swift mob justice. (Ask Yahoo!)

Remember the Google search monopoly? It still has a search monopoly, that may never change, but the rules of the game can change – as Microsoft found out with PCs. Google used to drive almost all of the traffic to popular sites. Now, it's a split between Google, Facebook and other social media sites. We didn't stop searching, we just started clicking on shared links more often than ever before.

It's in this regard that I think trying to lock people into a particular ecosystem or way of doing things is very risky. It still might work for Myntra (and Flipkart), but I have my reservations.

For starters, you're taking away discovery/impulse/casual buying. A friend shares a decent deal on a social networking site, and I click or tap it, and am told to install an app (assuming I don't already have it installed). To a commitment-phobe like me, that's expecting too

much. Sure, this is modern India, but it retains its quaint oddities too. We want to sample the goods before we commit to them. We want to taste before we buy a kilo. We want to kick the tyres, even though we all know that the tyres are the least important of all. We want to know that we'll be buying regularly from you before we waste precious phone memory on your app.

Perhaps the Chinese phone army will ensure that almost everyone in India has a smartphone, and enough storage for hundreds of apps. Perhaps, Airtel will ensure that everyone gets free internet access (to only its choice of services, of course), and perhaps Myntra will succeed with flying colours despite no website. Or perhaps not.

Now, a Junglee app makes sense to me... actually, bad example. What I mean is an app like that, but not made by one of the companies with vested interests in selling you stuff. An app that would allow me to quickly compare offers on Amazon, Ebay, Snapdeal, etc to a seemingly-awesome-but-ending-in-10-minutes offer from Flipkart. That's an app with value, as far as I'm concerned.

Besides randomly discovering a deal, even when searching for a pre-decided product, I know I want to check out many sites. I may use an app to actually do the buying from whoever I feel is cheapest, or best, or delivers fastest – based on my unique requirement at the time.

Who are these people who browse for stuff in an app? What do you do after that? Open/download five apps for five different companies, search all of them and then buy?

Have we reached some sort of monopoly already, and brand bias for e-retailers as well? Are there people who actually say, "I don't care about price, I only buy from <insert retailer name here>?"

Trying to lock me into your app for something like buying, which by definition is a comparison game, is just in-app-ropriate, and destined to fail. Or maybe I'm part of a fast-dying, insignificant, minority...What do you think? 



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